



Sports luminaries: Sheetal with Indian fast bowler Mohammed Shami during the Sportstar Aces Awards. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

bow with her feet, using her mouth to hold the arrow's bit, and consistently hitting the centre of the target board. This incredible feat helped her win the coveted Sportstar of the Year (Female) and Moment of the Year honours at the Sportstar Aces Awards.

On stage, with her coach Abhilasha Chaudhary and companion Romica by her side, Sheetal's acceptance speech belied her innocence. Like how a child would narrate a story during the school assembly, Sheetal went about telling her story, an exercise she has done countless times over the last five months.

"When I first saw archery, I never thought I could do it. Kuldeep sir (Kuldeep Kumar Vedwan, the army coach who spotted her) made a device for me with which I could shoot an arrow," the 17-year-old said.

Supported by the Shri Mata

Vaishno Devi Shrine Board (which also backs Paralympian Rakesh Kumar), Sheetal's journey in the sport began when she was spotted by officials belonging to the Indian Army's Rashtriya Rifles unit, who first chipped in with medical support and worked on and with her in sports. To get better at the sport, her coaches considered the use of prosthetics, but her physical challenge didn't allow her to do so with proper use of the arm, and hence, a girl who had learned to live with her legs doubled up as her hands learned to be an archer the same way.

"Sheetal is more able than others because her leg strength is so good; she is now the only woman in the world who shoots with her legs," Abhilasha said.

"I used to love going to school and would go with my brother. I began using my feet to write. I do everything in my life with my feet. I didn't know about the possibilities of



IN 2023

World No. 1 (As of November 27, 2023)

World Record holder in women's doubles event at Para Worlds
World's first armless woman archer

World Archery Para Championships 2023 silver
First female armless archer to win medal at the Para World Championships

Won three medals, including two gold and one silver in Asian Para Games 2023

First woman to win two gold medals at Asian Para Games 2023

Won three medals (2 gold, 1 silver) at Asian Para archery championship

First Indian to win Best Youth Athlete of the Year honour at Asian Awards 2023

sports. As kids, we would make wooden bows and play with them, but I never knew this would become a way of life for me. I consider my legs my hands. That's how I've always used them," Sheetal said.

Sheetal found her way to the Shrine Board and its coaches, Vedwan and Abhilasha, in 2022, and there was no looking back. The coaches had never worked with an armless archer before, and the pair drew immense inspiration from the story of Paralympic silver medallist Matt Stutzman, also an archer who shoots with his leg.

Customising equipment and pure hard work have brought Sheetal a long way, with the talent now a medal hopeful for India at the Paris Paralympics later this year.

"The best moment for me was when I won the individual gold at the Para Asian Games; the tricolour was flying high. My dream is to win the gold in Paris, too," she added.